

From an Internet Café to My Own Digital Café

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The first time I touched a computer, I was already around 24 years old.

I grew up in a poor family in the Philippines, so computers simply weren't part of my childhood. I didn't have one at home. I didn't grow up playing computer games or learning how software worked.

My first real experience with a computer happened in an internet café somewhere in Valenzuela, Philippines.

And I wasn't there because I wanted to learn programming.

I was curious about Friendster.

I wanted to understand how this strange thing worked.

How do people make profiles?

How do you add friends?

How does someone else's page appear on your screen?

I was fascinated by it.

At the time, I had absolutely no idea that one day I would be sitting in front of my own computer, building a website of my own.

If someone had told me that back then, I probably would have laughed.

Then somehow, I became good at IT

When I eventually continued my education in Denmark, IT wasn't actually my main field.

It was simply one of the many subjects I had to pass as part of my Gymnasium/EUX education.

There were plenty of subjects: mathematics, science, social studies, business economics, marketing, Danish, and others.

Most of them?

I was okay.

I passed.

Nothing particularly exciting.

Math was probably my next strongest subject. I got a 10.

But then there was IT.

I got a 12.

For anyone unfamiliar with the Danish grading system, 12 is the highest grade you can receive.

And that was kind of funny to me.

Here I was, someone who hadn't grown up with computers, who had first touched one at around 24 because I wanted to figure out

Friendster...

and somehow IT became the subject I excelled in.

Danish, meanwhile, was a completely different story.

I barely passed.

The lowest passing grade.

So if you ever wonder how I can build a website but still struggle with Danish sometimes...

There is your explanation.

I knew HTML and CSS. JavaScript was another story.

I learned HTML and CSS and developed a basic understanding of JavaScript.

I actually enjoyed creating things.

There was something satisfying about writing something and then seeing it appear on a screen.

But during my final project, I discovered something that really frustrated me.

Syntax errors.

A missing bracket.

A quotation mark in the wrong place.

One tiny character somewhere inside a pile of JavaScript.

Another person could look at the code and say:

"Oh, there it is."

And I could stare at the same thing for what felt like an eternity.

During my final project, I realized how much I struggled with finding those tiny mistakes.

Sometimes I wondered if I might have some mild dyslexic traits. I've never had that properly investigated, so I don't actually know.

And honestly, I didn't really want to find out.

I grew up with a very Filipino mentality:

What doesn't kill you makes you stronger.

So instead of stopping to investigate why I struggled with those little errors, I simply thought:

"Maybe IT isn't for me."

And I moved on.

I took a different road

I didn't pursue an IT-related education after that.

Instead, I went toward marketing.

Eventually, I moved into hospitality.

And I don't regret those choices.

Marketing taught me about communication, creativity, presentation, and how people connect with ideas.

Hospitality taught me about people, customer experience, service, and what makes a place feel welcoming.

At the time, I didn't realize how much those experiences would eventually influence something I would build years later.

Now, when I look at DigiCafe, I can see all those different pieces.

The hospitality side of me wants it to feel like a place.

The marketing side wants it to have an identity.

The creative side wants to fill it with stories, music, and ideas.

And the little part of me that enjoyed IT?

Apparently, she wasn't finished yet.

Years later, I came back to computers

I eventually found myself creating websites again.

Not because I suddenly became a professional developer.

I'm not.

I know HTML.

I know CSS.

I know basic JavaScript.

And I know how to spend an unreasonable amount of time searching for one missing character in my code.

But this time, there was no exam.

No teacher grading my work.

No final project I had to submit.

I was doing it because I wanted to.

That made the experience completely different.

I wasn't trying to prove that I belonged in IT.

I was simply curious again.

Just like that younger version of me who once sat in an internet café trying to understand Friendster.

Except this time, I wasn't just trying to understand someone else's website.

I was trying to build my own.

And then DigiCafe happened

DigiCafe started as an idea.

Then the idea kept growing.

At first, it was simply a website.

Then came stories.

Then music.

Then the Library.

Then audio.

Then PDFs.

Then Beshy.

Then comments and discussions.

And eventually, I started thinking:

What if this really felt like a café?

Not just a website with a café-inspired color scheme.

A real little digital place.

Somewhere you could enter.

Somewhere you could sit.

Somewhere you could listen to music.

Somewhere you could read.

Somewhere you could discover stories.

Somewhere you could leave a comment and talk to other people.

Somewhere you could simply spend a little time.

And suddenly, all those years of seemingly unrelated experiences started making sense.

I'm building a café because I understand cafés

My hospitality background probably has more influence on DigiCafe than I initially realized.

In hospitality, a place isn't just the furniture.

It's the experience.

It's how you feel when you enter.

It's the atmosphere.

The little details.

The feeling that someone thought about the person who would be sitting there.

That's what I want DigiCafe to have.

I don't want it to feel like a collection of webpages.

I want it to feel like a place.

That's why I started imagining an actual entrance door.

A lobby.

A music lounge.

A library.

A creative studio.

Maybe a cozy table with a cup of coffee.

Maybe headphones sitting beside it.

Maybe a comfortable chair in a quiet corner.

The website is still being built, but in my head, the café is already there.

Of course, things break

Because DigiCafe is a personal project, I am also the designer, developer, tester, content creator, problem solver, and the person who sometimes breaks something that was working perfectly five minutes earlier.

I've had to learn new things along the way.

Firestore.

Databases.

Audio players.

PDF readers.

Responsive layouts.

APIs.

AI.

And plenty of JavaScript problems.

Sometimes I know exactly what I'm doing.

Sometimes I absolutely do not.

Sometimes I fix something in five minutes.

Sometimes I spend hours trying to understand why something refuses to work.

And sometimes the answer is embarrassingly simple.

But that's okay.

I'm not trying to become a software engineer.

I'm learning because I have something I want to create.

And that's a very different kind of motivation.

From Friendster to DigiCafe

Sometimes I think about that first computer I touched in Valenzuela.

I was just curious about Friendster.

I wasn't thinking about websites.

I wasn't thinking about JavaScript.

I wasn't thinking about databases or AI.

I certainly wasn't thinking about creating my own digital café.

I was just trying to figure out how someone else's website worked.

And somehow, that curiosity stayed with me.

It took a very long route.

From the Philippines to Denmark.

From an internet café to a classroom.

From a 12 in IT to barely passing Danish.

From marketing to hospitality.

From leaving technology behind...

to finding my way back to it.

And now I'm here, building DigiCafe.

Maybe that's what being a late bloomer really means.

Maybe you don't necessarily arrive later.

Maybe you just take the scenic route.

And sometimes the scenic route turns out to be the interesting part.

I'm still building

DigiCafe isn't finished.

The content is still growing.

The design is still evolving.

Beshy is still learning.

There are features I haven't built yet, ideas I haven't tried, and probably plenty of bugs waiting for me somewhere in the code.

But I'm okay with that.

I'm not trying to become the person I might have been if I had chosen a completely different path.

I'm building DigiCafe with the person I actually became.

The girl who grew up without a computer.

The 24-year-old who discovered Friendster in an internet café.

The student who unexpectedly excelled in IT.

The person who decided not to pursue IT.

The marketing student.

The hospitality graduate.

The creative person.

The late bloomer.

All of those versions of me are somewhere inside this little digital café.

And maybe that's why DigiCafe feels so personal.

It isn't just a website I'm building.

It's a place where all those different parts of my life finally get to sit at the same table.

From an internet café in Valenzuela...

to my own digital café.

Welcome to DigiCafe.